

Nothing demonstrates the extent of this trade in ideas more than the history of Asian spices, especially ginger, pepper, nutmeg, cloves, cinnamon, and cardamom, which are all used extensively in Southeast Asian cooking. Many reached Europe via India in Roman times, and by the Middle Ages had become so valuable (due partly to assumed medicinal properties) that they fired the 16th-century European voyages of global exploration to discover their source, Indonesia's fabled "Spice Islands." Spanish, Portuguese, Dutch, and British explorers (or invaders and colonists) dominated the regional economies of Asia for the next four centuries, and they made one massive contribution to their cuisine by importing chili peppers from South America. So ubiquitous is the chili today in Asian cooking – it's used in dishes as varied as Sichuanese *gong bao* chicken, Thai green curry, Vietnamese *pho* (noodle soup), and countless relishes and spice pastes – that it's impossible to imagine how local cooks once managed without it.

Food is such an expression of culture in Asia that people's lives seem to revolve around it for much of the time. Eating here is always more than simply topping off the body's calories; it is, rather,

something to be indulged in or lavished upon others at every opportunity, with special dishes and feasting marking secular and religious festivals. Even the humblest meals can become social events; quiet, romantic restaurants are noticeably rare across much of Asia, where brightly lit, lively venues – the best of which are described in Chinese as being *renao*, or "hot and noisy" – are favored. That's not to say that there aren't rules; should someone inadvertently touch food with their left hand in Indonesia, onlookers would recoil in disgust at this breach of etiquette. But when wolfing down satay or nasi goreng at a street stand, or rubbing elbows with fellow diners in a south Indian thali house, the sheer enjoyment of eating seems to overwhelm the need to prescribe exactly how this should be done.

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Pan-Asian Cooking

The cuisine of Australia and New Zealand is very much that of the mostly European peoples who have colonized these islands in the last 200 years. Not that indigenous methods haven't had an impact: the famous Australian barbecue is only a step away from Aboriginal campfire cooking, illustrating a dominant "keep it simple" attitude to food. But the cuisine often self-consciously references European heritage or, in the case of Melbourne's Pan-Asian cuisine, fuses a whole region under one umbrella. Perhaps here, the setting is at least as important to the eating experience as the food; you can't really separate Balmain bugs from their coastal, Sydney-side spot.

Left Farm workers planting rice in a paddy field in Andhra Pradesh, India

Below Street food can be bought from stands and wandering vendors in Hoi An, Vietnam

